

Paths of Authority: Roads, the State and the Market in Eastern Zaire

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Markets for land, labour and goods in rural Zaire are embedded in autocratic and often corrupt local power domains which have been strengthened by economic crisis and concomitant structural adjustment policies. To talk of 'the market' in this context is as meaningless as to talk of 'the state'. The following article focuses on efforts to facilitate market integration through roadbuilding in rural areas, and on the way the advancing market affects the life chances of different local groups.

When regional planners and development agents glance at their maps of Kivu, in Eastern Zaire, they see the road network standing out in bold red ink, covering the entire region. The contrast between the map's optimistic promise and what the planners know to be reality is a potent reminder of economic decline and what has come to be known as the *mal Zairois*.

Although at independence in 1960 Zaire was the second most industrialised country in Africa, containing incredibly rich natural resources across a vast expanse of territory, its history has been a tragic one. Economic and educational opportunities for the people of Zaire were rigorously limited by the Belgian colonial administration; and after the departure of the Belgians, struggle among national factions for political and economic control degenerated into a civil war which lasted until 1967. Turmoil wrecked the economy and destroyed the institutional, administrative and legal structure.

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Therefore although the economy managed to flourish for a few years at the turn of the 1970s, buoyed by high commodity prices, the foundations of economic prosperity for rural Zairians had crumbled.

In 1973 foreign investments were 'Zairianised' and imported oil prices rose; and in 1974 the price of the country's principal mineral export (copper) collapsed. Financial reserves were rapidly depleted, and in 1975 Zaire defaulted on its debt for the first time.¹ This was followed by an agreement with the IMF in 1976, in which help in rescheduling debt and a standby loan were offered in exchange for devaluation, a cut in imports and government spending, and increased investment in agriculture. That such pledges had little effect is illustrated by the fact that debt was rescheduled again in 1977, 1979, 1980, 1981, and 1983.

In 1983, Zaire and the IMF agreed on a standby loan agreement which was conditional upon adoption of a standard structural adjustment package: massive devaluation, decontrol of producer prices (especially in the agricultural sector), reduction of public spending, trade liberalisation and revision of customs duties. Until 1986, creditors praised themselves (and Zaire) for their programme. Reform success was, however, premised on hopes for increased commodity prices and international aid, neither of which was forthcoming. Debt service rose from 11 percent of government expenditure in 1982 to 56 percent in 1985, and the government abandoned the adjustment reform programme in 1986 and 1987. Through default and rescheduling the official debt continued to rise, from 5.5 billion US dollars in 1985 to 8.5 billion in 1989 [Kawata, 1989]. Needless to say, the impact of the continuing crisis on levels of living, most particularly for those employed in the public sector, has been severe.

The real problems of economic reorganisation underlying the crisis are inextricably bound up with the nature of Zairian society and politics. The concept of 'state' authority has in fact always been problematic when applied to the area now contained within Zaire. The sheer size of the territory has constituted a brake on centralised control and favoured a kind of indirect exercise of authority through local intermediaries with wide and often despotic power over the population.

Personalistic, almost feudal control was in the first instance a fundamental trait of early Belgian colonialism. From 1895 until 1908, the Congo Free State was in fact a personal holding of King Leopold of Belgium; and appropriation of the labour, produce and taxes of those most easily subjugated was ensured through brutal treatment, including enslavement or threatened enslavement. Political control over regions in the 'interior', however, was most often minimal. Eventually, public outcry in Europe forced the Belgian government to assume responsibility for the territory, and the new administration and army of the Belgian Congo were gradually

able to widen their area of control through creating the structures of indirect rule which persist, to a greater or lesser degree, up to the present day.

Between the colonial administration and the populace, pliable intermediary Paramount Chiefs were installed with the influence necessary to force the population to accept orders and remain obedient. In Kivu, these chiefs, who rule over their *Collectivité*, were termed *Mwami* (plural *Bami*). Today they head what can euphemistically be called a 'traditional' political hierarchy consisting of sub-chiefs (*Chef de Groupement*), locality chiefs (*Chef de Localité*), and village chiefs (*Kapita*). *Bami*, reinforced by the territorial, regional and national administration above them, by the national army and their own police force, by their lucrative sale of chieftom land to Europeans, by their ability forcibly to recruit labour, and by their control over ivory and other trade, acquired far greater wealth and power over the population than ever before.

In the *Collectivité* of Bwisha in the Zone of Rutshuru, as elsewhere in Kivu, this powerful coercive coalition of state administrators, traditional administrators, army, police, and colonial entrepreneurs (in coffee, tea and quinine plantations) had a virtually free hand over many years to expropriate land from cultivators, to extort heavy taxes, and to recruit labour for work in the plantations, road building and infrastructure.

It took war-related famine during the 1940s to modify the terms of repression. The Belgian colonial administration declared labour to be free and attempted to curtail the authority of *Bami*, commercial plantations and national parks, which were often allied in corrupt and illegal ways [Mendiaux, 1956; Nzabandora, 1984]. The colonial administration was, however, weak in relation to these interest groups. In consequence, the programme intended to strengthen the power of the population (and administration) relative to traditional chiefs and capital, and to introduce local democracy, progressed slowly. New laws were still relatively ineffective at independence in 1960.

In some regions, like Bwisha, the freeing of labour did benefit ordinary people during the 1950s reform period and there was some success in curtailing the power of the *Bami*. During the anarchic period between 1960 and 1967, however, this trend was definitively reversed. Since that time, the chiefs have regained and reinforced their 'feudal' power, both as landlords and in alliance with investors, including national politicians. When foreign plantation capital was 'Zairianised' in 1973, for example, many of the spoils were taken by *Bami* and their sub-chiefs. And with the deepening economic crisis, decline in central financing of regional and local state government has forced state personnel, including the army, to rely on *Bami* and corruption for finance and income. The weakness of central authorities is exacerbated by the fact that state posts involve limited tenure, to prevent state bureau-

crats from building close and politically threatening alliances with local populations. Finally, the rhetoric of *authenticité* has favoured 'traditional' feudal leaders over modern 'state' ones.

In sum, therefore, the institution of 'the state' in Zaire may be terrifying and strong for the local population, but its control from the centre is actually very weak [Schatzberg, 1988]. Structural adjustment policies designed to 'roll the state back' are wrong to presuppose that the central state could exercise such control, even if its leaders had the political will to exert it [Thomas and Reintsma, 1989]. Furthermore, critics of structural adjustment who have argued that the IMF and World Bank 'now manage each country entirely' by imposing staff and vetting monetary, fiscal, tariff, trade and investment policies, and that this is the 'recolonization of Africa' [Onimode, 1987], would seem vastly to overestimate the role of the centre (be it Zairian or IMF) in managing the state, while significantly underestimating the importance of the 'second' or parallel economy [MacGaffey, 1987] and of 'second' or 'parallel' polities.

To talk of 'the market' in Zaire is as problematic as to talk of 'the state'. Just as the state is ultimately made up of territorially-based hierarchies of power, so too one finds that markets for land, labour and goods are locally bound, politically managed and thus anything but free. This 'underdevelopment' of the market is perceived by foreign advisors as a concomitant of the physical isolation and technological backwardness of rural people. In addition to mounting programmes which attempt to provide smallholder credit, extension services and access to new production inputs, then, the series of agricultural development efforts set in motion with international assistance over the past few decades – including the most recent efforts to bolster economic 'adjustment' through the promotion of agricultural growth – almost always has to consider the question of how to facilitate market integration through improving the rural communications network.

In 1972, the World Bank was instrumental in creating the Zairian road-building parastatal, Office des Routes; and in recent years money has continued to be channelled toward modernising transport, as a concomitant of project-based investment in agricultural extension and credit, and as support for programmes of producer price reform. As of 1984, the Bank had allocated US\$237 million to road and rail rehabilitation; and a donors' meeting held in March of the following year 'dealt exclusively with the transport sector' [Leslie, 1987: 103].

But what is the relation between expanding road networks, markets and rural 'development' in a context like that of Zaire? What kind of a market has been created in relatively isolated rural areas over the past few decades? Whose interests does the expanding road network serve and what kind of social change is promoted?

It is the contention of this article that questions like these must be answered very specifically, through reference to the evolution of livelihood strategies within particular rural environments over a substantial period of time. Furthermore, the development of the market for goods (and most importantly for food) must be examined as it interacts with changes in the markets for land and labour. Widening road networks affect the entire structure of resources available to various kinds of people, not simply the price of traded commodities. And even more important, perhaps, the impact of the market is felt not only among households (promoting social stratification and the coalescence of classes) but within them. Members of households experience market changes differently, with implications for the structure and meaning of community and family life.

A VIEW FROM BELOW: ROADS AS PATHS OF AUTHORITY

In the village in Eastern Zaire where I lived for 20 months between 1986 and 1988, roads were a big issue. Six kilometres from the village, down in the base of the Rift Valley which it overlooks, there is an important road, opened in 1958, which links the arterial Goma–Kisangani road with Uganda. Villages nearby have recently built access roads to this main road, and some people in Kakoma² wanted to do the same. Financial and technical assistance for road building was available from Programme Kivu (supported by the European Economic Community) and from Italian mission funds. Evidence from surrounding villages suggested that a road would improve the chances of establishing a market place in the village and attract more traders, encouraging higher producer prices and cheaper consumer ones. A nearby village had built an access road in 1984 and by 1986 had a thriving weekly market. Despite such benefits, however, there were clear differences of opinion concerning the advisability of constructing a road.

Divided interests were generated by concerns far broader than those of price or expanding economic opportunity. It should be understood at the outset that roads link the village with the outside world in a way which is qualitatively different from the links implied by the flow of goods and people along local pathways. From colonial times, roads were associated with the exercise of power by the state or the chiefs: forced labour was recruited to build them, personal movement along them was taxed and controlled, and indigenous land near them was expropriated for plantations and mission stations. In practice, this situation has changed little over the post-independence period. Roads still have to be built and maintained at vast labour expense. Roads make the surrounding land more attractive for commercial farming, and thus more valuable; and this still encourages land appropria-

tion by the powerful. And roads are still the site of forced exactions which make the ideal conception of the 'free market' of relatively limited utility in rural Zaire.

Direct Exaction

Many men are in fact afraid to walk along roads in Bwisha because they are likely to be robbed there by political *cadres*, the police of the *Mwami* and *Chef de Groupement*, the gendarmes, and the soldiers, all of whom tend to stay near roads when not on other duties. Robbery is often overt, although it can also be camouflaged through trumped-up charges. For example, each man in the village must carry receipts for tax payments and proof that he has voted, as well as a *Carte pour Citoyen*. Receipts, however, often cost more than the amount received, and identity cards are kept unavailable by the local authorities. Since men without these documents are fined on the spot and/or threatened with imprisonment if they are checked, and since checks on the road are frequent, the solution chosen by many is to avoid the roads.

Some men and all women are, however, protected from such banditry and hence consider roads more positively. Officials, who are rarely certain of their contextual authority over the strangers they rob, tend neither to approach nor to exact tribute from those who give the appearance of 'position', or those who can prove it. This means that the three primary school teachers, the five members of the Village Committee of the *Mouvement Populaire de la Révolution* (MPR), the village chief and his two deputies (all of whom are state functionaries and bear special identity cards) are protected. To show this, they often wear a Party badge when walking on the road.

Equally, three Protestant and three Catholic church officials are relatively immune from extortion, and the churches foster powerful political connections which protect the general congregation somewhat as well. For men, this is a very real reason for joining the church. Since Catholic and Baptist (CEBK) missionaries have good contacts with the *Commissaire de Zone*, the *Mwami*, and the military, they are even able to respond to complaints of the faithful by having offending soldiers arrested and stolen goods returned. Under such circumstances, it is not hard to understand the protective value some villagers accord to carrying bibles and wearing large crucifixes when journeying.

Others who can prove exemption from compulsory community labour (*solongo*, to be discussed below) also seem to enjoy relative immunity from direct expropriation by bandits on the road. Those who have proof of accredited employment have such exemption documents, as do those who work in 'development'. The latter group includes three members of a Village

Development Committee constituted in the framework of a local rural development centre, and two Red Cross paramedical health workers.

It should be noted that such immunity from extortion on the roads parallels forms of protection which have long been characteristic of rural life in Zaire. During pre-colonial and early colonial times, villagers derived similar security from membership in a patrikin-based community (*umuryango*, normally consisting of between 100 and 1,000 people) outside of which anyone could become the victim of anyone else. During the colonial period, employment in the plantations (and elsewhere) gave workers immunity from recruitment into other areas of forced labour, including road building. There has always been an important distinction between those who have protective ties or documents, showing them to be part of a greater community, and those who do not.

About a quarter of the men in the village where I lived can avoid direct expropriation and find it relatively safe to use the roads. Church officials of all denominations, school teachers, development workers and health workers, form a distinct group of common outlook. Not surprisingly they are also the wealthier villagers. Wealth makes it easier to gain positions of protection and vice versa.

Women have a different experience. They are relatively free of direct expropriation on the roads and in markets. They resent illegal taxation strongly, and can be very aggressive towards officials who attempt to impose it. Women tend to walk to market in groups and physically to protect each other against the officials they encounter on their journeys. Newbury has documented a revolt by women over increased taxes elsewhere in Kivu, and shows how, just as in Bwisha, their liberty gives them certain marketing advantages over men:

... men 'hide behind women' in marketing their peanuts. Men send women to carry peanuts to market these days (say the women) for reasons of security. A man who has just received 150 zaires or more for a *mbweka* of peanuts is fair game for gendarmes who prowl about Bulambika market seeking potential victims to be relieved of their earnings on the basis of some trumped-up charge. Alternatively a man with money in his pocket at market finds that this disappears quickly when friends and relatives call on him to buy them drinks. These problems do not arise when women carry peanuts to the market [1984b: 46-7].

Labour Exactions

In order to understand the differential distribution of benefits and dis-benefits associated with the construction of the road, the institution of

solongo, or unpaid community labour, must also be briefly discussed. For pre-colonial patrikin communities, *solongo* was labour tribute which a newcomer would give to his hosts. Under Belgian rule, however, it became the compulsory labour (60 days/year, raised to 120 days/year during the Second World War) exacted from all those without accredited employment. *Solongo* is thus a form of labour tribute to the powerful, and not community labour in any meaningful sense of the term.

Solongo is organised by representatives of the traditional and state hierarchy: the village chief (*Kapita*) and his seniors, and the president of a village *comité de base* of the MPR. These coexisting political structures overlap (often competitively) in jurisdiction, and there are frequent disputes over the rights of each to *corvée* labour. Common *solongo* tasks include cultivating the fields of the *Mwami* and his sub-chiefs (including the village *Kapita*), building and maintaining their houses, building and maintaining roads, and on rare occasions, maintaining social infrastructure such as schools and clinics. Superiors justify their private use of 'state' labour by claiming that it is payment for what are otherwise unpaid posts. Obviously, such a situation allows chiefs to translate political power into economic gain.

There are, however, ways to avoid the *corvée*. The *Kapita* permits relatives, friends and respected men to evade normal *solongo* work in Bwisha if they pay 20 litres of banana wine and a chicken. This reduces the number who do *solongo* to twenty or so men who are young and poor. Nevertheless payment of tribute to chiefs signifies powerlessness on the part of the petitioner and consequent dependence on the continuing goodwill of the chief. Those who avoid *solongo* in this way cannot refuse the subsequent frequent supplementary demands which the *Kapita* makes, and life becomes financially insecure.

Men who bribe the *Kapita* nevertheless gain a certain independence from the state within the village. They, and the *Kapita*, realise that if a road were built to the village, the power of the *Kapita* would wane, and with it their unofficial exemption. The road would permit those in higher political positions living outside the village to take more direct control over village affairs, expropriate labour directly, and manage lucrative tribunals, while at the moment higher authorities have only indirect, inefficient control via the village chief.

Women are exempt from *solongo*. On one occasion, they successfully organised themselves against it when forced to plant cassava for the *Chef de Groupement*. Angry and worried by the precedent, they cut the nodes (eyes) off the cassava stems which they planted. The crop did not grow. It is said that the astonished chief suspects sorcery to this day, and he has not forced the women to work again.

In summary, many of those who will have to build the road are not in

favour of road building, as they would effectively be building the vehicle of their own oppression. As during colonial times, when roads were built by the forced labour of men unfortunate enough to be unable to escape recruitment, the burden of road building falls on unprotected men. This includes people who do *solongo* at present (young, poor, powerless men, especially recent immigrants without family contacts in the village) and the many who avoid *solongo* because of their position relative to the chiefs (better placed men without official institutional jobs). Only those men who are immune from *solongo* and hence immune from road building, who pursue their own lives with some measure of security, and whose authority may actually be increased by better access to missionaries, development personnel and traders, favour road building. It is these people who development experts are likely to meet. Women, who are rarely robbed on roads, who are exempt from building them, and who presently suffer in carrying produce long distances to market, seem to side with the protected men on this issue. They do not necessarily see eye to eye with their husbands.

Expropriation of Land

In spite of deepening economic crisis in Zaire, there has been a great increase in demand on the part of entrepreneurs and politicians for large tracts of plantation land during the 1980s [Katuala Kaba *et al.*, 1986], and this demand is now being accentuated by infrastructural improvements [Schoepf and Schoepf, 1987]. As inflation erodes the value of stored money and as trade is a relatively risky and difficult occupation, those in politically superior positions currently prefer to store and reproduce wealth in cattle and in land, that is, in cattle ranching. At the same time, infrastructural decay and the collapse of coffee prices has also led plantation owners to uproot coffee and switch to cattle. Ranching is easy, less risky and lucrative. There is a large, experienced and skilled local Batutsi workforce. At the same time, gaining control over land serves to gain greater control over labour, to force down wage rates and pass the burden of economic decline on to a more securely tied labour force.

In Kivu, livestock is now almost the only profitable investment; and its profitability is increased by aid organisations. Canadians have funded the construction of a modern abattoir which has improved meat processing; and with the development of air freight, Kivu cattle ranchers now have access to the Kinshasa market. In tandem, FAO, the Canadian-funded ACOGENOKI, and the American Peace Corps have all invested heavily in the development of cattle ranching. They provide education, advice and direct inputs to improve pasture management and veterinary care. And loans from commercial and development banks (like the Agricultural Credit

Bank) have been made available at preferential interest rates to well placed investors in livestock [Schoepf and Schoepf, 1987]. President Mobutu himself has castigated the Agricultural Credit Bank (partially funded by the World Bank) for not meeting the needs of peasants, and for favouring the wealthy who expropriate land (see the Kivu newspaper ELIMA, 8/12/84).

The people of Bwisha have recent experience with the expansion of large landholdings across their village lands. In 1984, the owner of the massive ex-colonial plantation which borders on the village extended the border of his holding by about 500 yards. He claimed that the original borders (defined on maps in the land registration office far away in Bukavu) were further into the village than the markers (concrete slabs) showed. He asserted that the villagers had encroached on the plantation and moved its boundary markers. This was falsification. The plantation owner was well connected and wealthy, and, villagers say, was able to pay off a surveyor and others to validate his claim. His action reduced the land area of the village by about a quarter. Many people found their houses and fields incorporated within the new boundary; and they subsequently faced the choice of continuing to live in the plantation and giving up both one day a week's labour and their autonomy to it, or moving out. They moved out, charging that the plantation was purposefully extended to gain authority over them, as the owner wanted free labour.

ADMINISTRATION PROLIFERATION AND DECENTRALISATION

Changes in the balance of power between regional and local administrators and public employees, on the one hand, and the central government on the other, are further exacerbating the insecurity of unprotected cultivators in many regions of Zaire. The financial crisis of the state and the need for structural adjustment have made decentralisation a necessity for the government. Regions have been granted more autonomy, and local administrative units have been told to look after themselves as the central government can no longer afford to fund their activities [Leslie, 1987: 74; Newbury, 1984a: 112-15].

At the same time, decentralisation has been accompanied by a proliferation of authorities which inhabitants must endure. Thus in July 1982, popularly elected councils at the level of *Collectivité*, the zone and the region were established in Kivu [Newbury, 1984a]. In 1988, MPR 'MOPAP' representatives at the *Groupeement* level were appointed. In 1988, new *Cités* were created and new chiefs installed in them. In 1989, Kivu was divided into three regions. North Kivu, previously a sub-region, became a region and new administrative personnel and infrastructure had to be built. To raise revenues, new taxes have been introduced and old ones increased,

especially at the level of the *Collectivité* in the rural areas, and at the zone and sub-region levels in urban areas.

Decentralisation has devolved further power onto those exercising authority in rural areas: the feudal chiefs, wealthy businessmen, plantation owners, soldiers and to a lesser extent, wealthy villagers. As has historically been the case, once plantation owners, traditional chiefs and the military acquire greater autonomy and forge alliances among themselves (and also now with state politicians), unprotected cultivators suffer more insecure land rights and reduced freedom of labour. As Newbury has documented: 'State and local authorities collaborated in forcing residents off their land and providing labour and other resources, in return for certain services and other prerogatives from the plantation companies' [Newbury, 1986: 102]. Hired military harassment, 'arrests, extortion, and crop destruction are used against farmers who refused to abandon homes and fields coveted by those in power' [Schoepf and Schoepf, 1988: 111].

To sum up, then, although planners might consider road building to be synonymous with development, the concrete situation prevailing in the Zairian countryside during this period of crisis and adjustment implies that as the landscape is 'developed' by building roads, and as agriculture (ranching) is made more profitable, the developed landscape and its developed economy is unfortunately appropriated.

THE MARKET, THE ROADS AND FOOD SECURITY

Issues of direct expropriation of land, labour and money do not satisfactorily account for the differing opinions and factions over the road question. Attitudes are influenced by certain current and deeply felt social changes associated with roads. In particular these concern the way that roads affect the relationship between spouses within households (*urugo*). Women and men can use roads and marketing as resources in their struggle to maintain or improve their respective economic status in increasingly impoverished households. As they do so, however, their actions contribute to changing the way work is organised in the household and in the village; and this in turn affects the entire farming system, which has important implications for food security.

Food security used to be an aspect of general security which depended on membership in one of the 100 or so large patrikin communities (*umuryango*) in Bwisha. Every aspect of past food provisioning (cultivation, storage, eating, gifts and exchanges) invoked social allegiances and duties. Cultivating together in large groups (*guguzanya*), as well as the existence of formal (tribute) and informal transfers of food and labour, were the essence of alliance and community.

The community nature of food security is exemplified by the organisation of work groups. Although land for seasonal crops was allocated to each household, cultivation involved large, gender specific work groups which cultivated the plot of each household in turn. Participants in women's groups received gifts of a basket of food each day, and at harvest women received a large basket of millet from those who had not reciprocated their labour. Villagers with poor yields had little difficulty in acquiring food.

Food could be solicited in times of shortage from one's network of interdependents, which might include relatives, trading partners and friends. Persistent food transfers among these groups reinforced the relationship. Surpluses and shortages in different households were balanced through informal gift giving and reciprocity, more in terms of friendship, perhaps, than along strict kinship lines, but usually among relatives nevertheless.

Networks of interdependents span the highly diversified agro-ecological regions of Bwisha. Farmers alter their crops, timing and techniques according to the different climatic conditions and land availability found over a wide range of altitudes. In densely populated regions of high altitude on the Rift Valley escarpment, or on the foothills of the volcanoes (from 1,800–2,800m), farming is conditioned by low temperatures and long rainy seasons (around 2,500mm of rain per year) and by land scarcity. In contrast, on the less densely populated base of the Rift Valley at less than 1,000m, farmers adapt to high temperatures and short, distinct rainy seasons (with around 1,000mm of rain per year).

Different crops and varieties are of course suited to particular altitudes. At higher altitudes farmers grow sorghum, beans, potatoes, maize and peas whereas at lower altitudes they cultivate bananas, cassava, millet, beans, maize, peanuts and coffee. Thus during the two altitude-specific cultivation seasons, when low food stocks coincide with high labour demands, nearby regions at other altitudes have abundant food, and social links have traditionally been used to solicit food from interdependents there. If a seasonal failure of the crop affected one region, food could also be obtained from other regions which were not so affected.

Food security and the benefits of complementarity were therefore assured mainly within large communities and social networks which linked peoples of different ethnic groups, occupations and agro-ecological areas. Spreading one's network duties and responsibilities far and wide was advantageous, and alliances with distant communities through marriage and blood pacts (*ukunyana*) were frequent.

Prudent leaders also stored millet and sorghum as famine reserves. Millet stores almost indefinitely, and sorghum lasts about two years. Through the tribute and taxation system, local and regional chiefs could build up strategic

stocks which they could then use to their advantage during times of hunger. Although surplus food production usually had no value except as gifts, in times of famine it could even be exchanged for cattle, or used to attract dependent labourers. Dangerous, temporary markets formed during famines.

Except for such times of scarcity, these non-capitalist forms of production and exchange generally underwrote not only the food consumption of villagers, but also of workers on the plantations and in the mines. Plantation workers did not purchase food but were fed by their families; and to feed the mineworkers, farmers in their locality (although not in Bwisha) were compelled to deliver non-commercialised surpluses. Thus the plantation system left 'no base for an African rural petty capitalism nor for an African peasant agriculture' [Peemans, 1986: 72].

The system of collective responsibility for food security just described has crumbled under the impact of a number of changes, including a very high level of population growth. Between 1929 and 1986, the population of Bwisha rose from 63,000 to 263,000, implying a shift in the ratio of inhabitants per hectare of land from 46 to 192. Land shortages are now very acute in the highlands and the traditional system of land lending, through structures of clientelism outside the boundaries of the market, has broken down. Land has become a commodity which can be bought and sold, and land is rented at commercial rates. In Bwisha, the 47 per cent of all village households without sufficient land to sustain themselves in areas of traditional jurisdiction have no choice but to farm in the derelict plantations at the cost of a man-day of *corvée* per week. Patrilineal communities have fragmented.

A market for food developed in tandem with these agrarian changes, and as an outgrowth of related developments within the labour market. The sale of food was apparently insignificant in Bwisha until the 1950s [Drevet, 1977], when the abolition of unfree labour arrangements created some limited monetary demand for food products. This process gathered considerable momentum during the following decade, however, as food markets developed spontaneously in the deregulatory and chaotic aftermath of independence, when prices skyrocketed in expanding urban centers. The economic crisis of the past two decades has further drawn rural households into the market. Opportunities to migrate or engage in nearby wage labour have declined and it has become necessary to sell household crops in order to obtain cash, even when production should be consumed by the household itself.

Thus food security now depends more on using the market well than on creating alliances well. Buying food in the market, trading for profit, and day labour (often in other ecological zones) have become important strategies

for meeting personal food deficits. At the same time, the tendency to withhold gifts and keep potentially profitable stores private during periods of hardship (in spite its moral wrongness), although not new, is spreading. Women of poor families cannot meet the food requests of friends and their 'obligations' to relatives. Those well-off women who can do so find that their support networks have shrunk because migration and land commoditisation has fragmented kin-based residential communities. The 'community' as constructed in (and dependent for its existence on) food gifts and land loans has become limited to the close family and perhaps the few other relatives, church-goers, and neighbours with whom good relations are maintained. Gifts are harder to solicit and are considered in terms of exact (value) reciprocity.

Such trends are viewed with anxiety by the people of Bwisha. Good 'community relations' are locally contrasted with bad 'market' ones. For many, the need to procure food from the market, especially soon after harvest, still indicates a 'lack of community' and earns disrespect. (The ideal of 'not having to buy food' should, however, not be confused with 'self-sufficiency'. The ideal is premised on upholding community relations, not on the risk averse and secure food provisioning strategy of any single 'co-operative household unity'.) The competition between family members for diminishing household resources is so great that households which have such common purpose are now hard to maintain.

CONFLICTS OF INTEREST IN HOUSEHOLDS, AND THEIR RESOLUTION

From the 1970s onward, the growing importance of the market for food crops and decline in the social value of non-market food exchanges have created confusion within households over the rights of different members to sell or otherwise control the use of these crops. Ambiguities arise in particular because men may consider that they control household wealth (which in earlier times did not encompass food, since food was not marketed), whereas women have always considered the disposal of food crops as their concern. This ongoing and unresolved conflict is covered up when household relations are harmonious, as due consideration is paid by each spouse to the other; but it becomes apparent whenever relations deteriorate, and most especially when supplies are running short.

Ambiguities in control over harvests are worse in certain circumstances. First, if food is stored in the house, because problems of rights to it become problems of storage itself. Second, if crop production requires a considerable input from men, since men are more inclined to consider food crops which they helped to cultivate as theirs. Third, if the harvests are bulky and valuable, since men consider bulk stores of seasonal produce as under their

control. Large stores also tempt husbands to reduce the financial assistance they provide to wives for the purchase of items such as clothes.

Under such circumstances, many (especially poorer) women engage in strategies to avoid losing control. They cultivate crops which men participate less in producing, they cultivate out of seasonal patterns to limit bulk supply, and they sell stocks earlier.

Crops with Less Participation on the Part of Men

Women cannot easily sell the major crops, such as millet, sorghum and climbing beans, which men help them to produce; but it is harder for men to dispute their wives' exclusive rights to any inter-crops they plant. Thus, for example, while women may not control millet (the household crop par excellence), they do control its inter-crops (for example, sorghum). The new food crops (cassava, bush beans, soja and colocasia) which have been adopted since the mid-1970s, and which now predominate for many households in Bwisha, were in fact all introduced by women as inter-crops.

Women plant cassava wherever they can get away with it, inter-cropped with millet, peanuts, bush beans, soja and coffee, or on its own in an exhausted field. They plant colocasia in coffee groves, on the fringe of banana groves, and on odd plots near the house. In Bwisha, as Guyer [1986: 100] has argued elsewhere, field and inter-cropping types which women control have become the backbone of the food system, whereas crops which men help produce have greatly diminished in importance.

Aseasonal Production

Women now sow seasonal crops such as beans and maize over longer periods; and making use of varieties of variable precocity, they harvest them over even longer spans of time. Seasons are less demarcated, harvest periods are longer, and storage is reduced. Storage is more 'in the field' than in the house.

The trend toward aseasonal crop production (and thus toward women's control over food cropping) is accentuated because intensive agriculture, inter-cropping and modern labour relations favour both the production of such aseasonal root crops as sweet potatoes and cassava, and the creative use of crop varieties and associations which break with old seasonal timings.

Selling

Women find it easier to store money than food, as money can be stored secretly, perhaps in women's savings groups (*ikibina*) where cash is secure

from other claimants. Money can then be used as working capital for trading. By selling 'too much', women can also manage crises. During periods of difficulty, husbands are responsible for making up shortfalls of food or seed; and women can use this reversal of household obligations to force men to provide more for the family. In consequence, the increased use of the market in food provisioning seems not merely to be an outgrowth of land shortage and poverty, but to be accentuated by the struggle over rights to household produce.

Market integration is further exaggerated by very large price variations which tempt cultivators to speculate with their food stores. A higher proportion of food reaching the market, a greater reliance on purchases from it, and more long-distance traders who bring external influences to local markets, all magnify price fluctuations. In January 1987, the price of beans was Z 600 per sack; by July 1987 it had climbed more than tenfold to Z 7,200, and then by December, it had fallen to Z 2,400. In 1988, beans were at Z 2,500 per sack in June, but by December 1988 they had gone up four fold to Z 10,000. In 1989, things were different: in June 1989, a sack cost Z 21,000 but by November the price had halved to Z 10,000.

The potential for such huge price changes makes the gains or losses from speculation tremendous. No one can avoid being a speculator: one becomes a speculator even by default. Therefore, correct market decisions have become as important as correct production ones. And the inescapable necessity to 'play the market' strongly influences the provisioning strategies of households.

While there used to be a division of household labour *within* the production of unmarketed 'household' crops (millet, sorghum and climbing beans), the tendency as shown above is now for labour to be divided *between* crops which can be sold for cash: women concentrate on certain new crops, and men concentrate on others, including bananas and coffee. Old 'household' crops have as a result become marginalised.

This tendency is somewhat mitigated, however, by other arrangements which can be made to allocate communally cultivated crops individually while removing the ambiguity inherent in joint productive activities. For example, a field can be allocated to an individual (man or woman) who grows private crops (any crop, be it old or new, normally men's or normally women's) for his or her own unambiguous financial benefit (*kwihalika*). Such arrangements were previously made only for boys, but they are now made between spouses.

To accommodate the gender division of labour between spouses (or unmarried men and women) who are embarking on private production, reciprocal arrangements are made of the nature: 'if *you* (man) clear *my* (woman) bean field then *I* (woman) will sow *your* beans or weed *your* coffee,

or buy *you* some beers, or give *you* some money at harvest.' Such arrangements are understood between (and so instantiate the presence of) economic 'individuals', and they occur at every stage of production and consumption. In polite society these arrangements are disapproved of: *kwikora* (to work for oneself) is considered *kwireba* (to be selfish). To avoid this, some families overcome conflicts of interest over ambiguously controlled crops by allocating harvests to projects (food, school fees, women's clothes, a bicycle, a tax, bridewealth) before cultivation, rather than leaving their use ambiguous or earmarking them anti-socially for individuals.

The new individualism and reliance on the market have major dietary implications. Greater use of aseasonal and associated crops means that cassava and maize have largely replaced millet. Earlier selling implies that the diet is downgraded to hunger season foods earlier, and that many people rely on day labour, food purchase and other coping strategies earlier in the hungry season. Changes in the marketing and consumption of beans testify to this. They are increasingly a luxury which poorer people eat in quantity only at harvest time. In general, they are sold; and the proceeds are used to buy low-value bulk foods like cassava. Concomitantly, farmers choose varieties which sell better, rather than those which 'taste good' or which are better suited agro-ecologically.

As households have less local control over their diet, the latter also varies more throughout the year, because of seasonal fluctuations in food prices and seasonal differences in the purchasing power of farmers. Integration into the market renders poor villagers very vulnerable to large price increases, like those which occurred in 1989, when the price of basic staple foods (cassava and maize) rose to 700 per cent of the level prevailing during previous years. On that occasion, famine threatened Bwisha.

MARKETS, ROADS AND SOCIAL CHANGE

It should now be clear how diets and food provisioning strategies indicate to Banyabwisha certain forms of economic and social relations in the household and community. Diet is at the centre of personal, class and ethnic identities, all of which are changing rapidly. Some groups and individuals are gaining, but most are losing, as market incorporation proceeds. And even in the case of those who are able to devise new strategies for defending their interests, gains are won at a price: those women who see that the road might help them both to 'get by' and to battle for their economic rights in the household, but who also see that it might exacerbate the reasons for that battle, have realised the intractability of their situation.

Do the standard prescriptions of adjustment-related food policy have any relevance to basic livelihood dilemmas in a region like Bwisha? Agreement

between the national government and international creditors to limit the role of the state in marketing, and to increase producer prices, is obviously irrelevant in the context of the market for agricultural products of the kind just discussed. Prices are being determined in a highly fragmented and circumscribed market, still in the process of development. Women sell food produce and men sell coffee in weekly markets by the road, where local purchasers compete with traders who come on foot from other regions or who have lorries. The state plays no part in this, except to the extent that public officials form part of the group of local power-holders who levy fines and collect bribes in the markets and on the roads. This is as much an example of private initiative as of public policy.

Developing a better network of roads can of course in principle serve to integrate the fragmented market and to smooth out the enormous variation in prices for food products which currently threatens the livelihood of the poor in areas like Bwisha. Roads in themselves, however, are not the issue. Their impact depends upon who controls them; and the situation described above is congruent with a violent and monopolistic form of market intervention, not one which fosters impartial competition.

The livelihood of most people in Bwisha is currently very precarious, for a variety of reasons having to do not only with the broader economic crisis, but also with climatic disturbances, epidemic diseases of cassava, the growing nightmare of AIDS, the collapse of coffee prices, erosion and declining soil fertility, as well as social disorganisation and the collapse of collective mechanisms of support. Village land is being expropriated as a concomitant of the expansion of cattle ranching, which rural development programmes tend to encourage. The number of landless is growing. Imposition of requirements to provide free labour services ensures that many people work part of the time for nothing; and even when they work for wages, the real level of remuneration for their labour is declining. Extortion, corruption and taxes are on the rise. The problem of survival in Bwisha is complex indeed, and the view from above is extraordinarily simple.

NOTES

1. Unless otherwise referenced, data on Zaire's debt situation is taken from Leslie's comprehensive analysis of the relationship of Zaire with the IMF and World Bank [Leslie, 1987].
2. Throughout this article, fictitious names have been used to identify field sites.

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